sending two infantry battalions of 67 Infantry Brigade to reinforce Bomdila. The troops would move through the night and be available by morning. Later in the evening, there was yet another conversation between Kaul and Gurbax Singh who said that even though a fighting patrol had been readied, they were pinned down by defensive fire just 400 metres from the forward defences of Bomdila.

Kaul's briefing on the morning of 18 November was based entirely on assumptions. He presumed that 62 Infantry Brigade was in the process of withdrawing from Senge towards Dirang, and would clear the roadblocks en route. He did not seem to realize the implications of his own earlier orders giving Anant Pathania permission to withdraw from Dirang Dzong. He believed that once the Se-la and Dirang Dzong forces had married up, they would then jointly roll down to Bomdila. Kaul didn't seem to have a real idea of the strength of the Chinese thrust across Poshing-la. In the absence of any actual information, the big three could only speculate and stare at the map in the fond hope that some miraculous solution would fall into their laps.

Coming back to the situation in Bomdila, Kaul informed Thapar and Sen that there had been a delay in the dispatching of two battalions from 67 Infantry Brigade the previous night as vehicles were not available to transport troops forward. These battalions would now reach Bomdila by midday. Kaul also informed them that Gurbax Singh had admitted that the previous night's reports pertaining to the Chinese closing in on Bomdila's defences had proved to be exaggerated. The roadblock between Bomdila and Dirang Dzong was still in place, as the tanks and the infantry were yet to marry up. Kaul once again reiterated that in his opinion, the strength of the Chinese facing Bomdila had to be extremely limited, both in terms of numbers and heavy weapons.

At 11 a.m., Kaul was put through to Gurbax Singh. Once again, he was told that the road-clearing party had not yet left Bomdila. Kaul at this point categorically told Gurbax Singh to send out the column immediately or he would be removed from command.

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Gurbax Singh put the phone down and tried to collect his thoughts. Normally quite cool and collected, he had tried everything to keep the defences of Bomdila intact, but now the corps commander was leaving him